What We Will Watch: Twelve Ordinary Things to Notice About How the Care Is Going

Everyday things about the tasks, the time and who knows what, to notice and write down.

The arrangement works, more or less, and you'd like to keep an eye on it without becoming the family inspector. This guide names twelve ordinary things worth noticing about the tasks, the time they take and who knows what, and for each one, what to write down.

Notice and record. Don't interpret. This guide doesn't say what any of these means, and a page of notes doesn't say how the arrangement is doing. The notes are for the family's next conversation and for the professionals you talk with. The items come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step. Where one follows a public source it is marked, and the wording about what to write down is ours.

The work itself

1 What's new on your list [1]

NOTICE Something you do for him now that you didn't do a year ago: personal care, meals, his pills, the driving, the bills.

WRITE DOWN The task, roughly when it became yours, and how often it comes around.

2 What takes longer than it used to

NOTICE A task that has been yours for years and now fills more of the morning, or needs two trips where it used to need one.

WRITE DOWN The task, and about how long it takes now. A rough figure is fine.

3 What happens at the edges of the day

NOTICE The things that get done late at night or early in the morning.

WRITE DOWN Which tasks, and about what time.

4 What only one person knows how to do [2]

NOTICE The jobs with one expert: how his pills are set out, who to call at the doctor's office, where the papers are kept.

WRITE DOWN Each job, who knows it, and whether anyone else has ever done it.

Who does what

5 What is clearly someone's job [3]

NOTICE The tasks where a person is named and the two of you have actually talked about it.

WRITE DOWN The task and the name.

6 What is assumed [4]

NOTICE A task you think one of the kids handles, or one they think you handle, that nobody has ever discussed.

WRITE DOWN The task, who you think does it, and the words “never discussed.”

7 What didn't happen when it usually does

NOTICE A regular task that slipped: a refill picked up late, an appointment rescheduled, a bill found under the mail.

WRITE DOWN What it was and the date. If it happens again, write that down too. No reasons needed.

8 Offers, and what came of them [4]

NOTICE Something a relative said they would do, and whether it happened.

WRITE DOWN The offer and what happened, as facts. Leave out any word about what kind of person they are.

What gets said

9 What your husband says about it [5]

NOTICE What he says, in passing or when asked, about how things are going and what he'd like to keep doing himself.

WRITE DOWN His words, with the date, kept apart from what the family thinks.

10 Offers of help, and the answer [6]

NOTICE The moments when someone asks whether they can lend a hand, and what gets said back. “Thanks, but I'm fine” counts.

WRITE DOWN Who offered, what they offered, and the answer.

11 Two accounts of the same week [4]

NOTICE Your daughter after a visit, your son on the phone and your husband himself describing how things are, and not in the same way.

WRITE DOWN Each account beside the others, with whose it is. Don't choose one.

12 The subject that doesn't get raised [7]

NOTICE A topic that comes up and gets changed, or one you rehearse and don't say. A disagreement about more support for him, or about a move, goes here too.

WRITE DOWN The subject in one line, and who sees it differently. Not who is right.

When a note isn't enough

This list is about the arrangement, not about anyone's health. A worry about your husband's health isn't a note for the next family conversation: tell his doctor. The National Institute on Aging suggests a visit to a health care provider when you're concerned about a person's physical or mental health. For your own health, the Institute's advice to caregivers is to tell your doctor that you are a caregiver.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these mean, whether the arrangement is working, or whether your husband needs more help. It leaves his health and yours to the people who look after them. Your notes are what you bring to the people who can look at the whole picture.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to watch and how to write it down. The care interview takes those notes further: it walks you through your husband's needs and the help around him area by area, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. National Institute on Aging, Getting Started With Caregiving
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
5. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
6. National Institute on Aging, Taking Care of Yourself: Tips for Caregivers
7. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families